After New Delhi announced a ban on religious gatherings of over 50 people on 16 March and effectively began to gradually shut down, several attendees at the Banglewadi Nizamuddin Masjid Markaz vacated the property, taking buses, trains and planes fanning out to different parts of the country. Two initial incidents raised the alarm that the masjid may have become a COVID-19 hotspot, with thousands of missionaries still housed inside the building. A man, from Karimnagar district in Telangana who was hosting a group of 10 preachers and had arrived by train on 14 March from the Markaz, tested positive for coronavirus after displaying symptoms. On contact tracing, the state authorities tracked down all the 10 preachers, out of which eight tested positive for the virus. As soon as the results came back, the state government announced restrictions in a 3 km radius around their movement area, making it a 'containment zone', the first of many to come over the next couple of months.[14]

Earlier in the week, on 13 March, a frail-looking Thai national who had returned from the Markaz was stopped by the authorities at Coimbatore airport. He was admitted to the hospital but passed away on 17 March due to renal failure. The authorities were able to contact trace members of the group of Jamaat returnees he was travelling with before he passed away and send their samples for testing.[15]

As per information received from these groups, even though the congregation itself was a three-day event, several groups of missionaries were travelling to various parts of the country before and after the congregation to recruit more people. It was more of a rolling affair which was taking place in the first two weeks of March. As per an estimate, 2,100 foreigners visited India for Tablighi activities since 1 January, while approximately 824 of them, as on 21 March, had disseminated to various parts of the country for recruitment and missionary work after being present at the congregation.[16] About 216 foreign missionaries were estimated to still be in the masjid, in addition to over 1,500 Indian Jamaatis.

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19 MARCH 2020

INDIA | 170 ACTIVE CASES | 4 DEATHS

WORLD | 2,20,366 ACTIVE CASES | 10,198 DEATHS